Simple Business English

How to Report a Project Delay to Your Boss | Business English for Meetings

Situation: Chloe walks into Victor's office on Thursday morning. The launch of a new snack bar line is planned for March 1st, but the printing house just reported a major equipment failure.
Chloe — Project Manager for New Product Launches · **Victor** — Commercial Director

Transcript

Chloe: Good morning, Victor. Do you have five minutes to discuss the snack bar launch?
Victor: Good morning, Chloe. Yes, come in and sit down. What is on your mind?
Chloe: I have an urgent update regarding our new snack bar launch.
Victor: All right. We are still on schedule for the March first rollout, right?
Chloe: I must be direct with you. The launch date is at risk.
Victor: What do you mean at risk? The retail planograms are already locked.
Chloe: The printing house called an hour ago. The packaging is delayed by two weeks.
Victor: Two weeks? Are you telling me we will have no packaging until mid-March?
Chloe: Yes, exactly. Their main printing machine broke down on Monday evening.
Victor: Why am I only hearing about this major problem on Thursday?
Chloe: They tried to fix the machine in-house, but they failed and only notified us today.
Victor: This is a disaster, Chloe. Retailers will charge us severe penalty fees.
Chloe: I understand that completely. It puts our entire first quarter target in danger.
Victor: Not just the target! They could remove our product from the shelves before we even start.
Chloe: You are right, Victor, and we cannot let that happen under any circumstances.
Victor: Why did we not set up a backup printer for this launch?
Chloe: We chose this supplier because their production price was twenty percent lower.
Victor: A lower price means nothing if we miss the launch window. **We cannot afford to miss this.**
Chloe: I agree with you. I should have verified their progress earlier this week.
Victor: Yes, you should have. Constant follow-up is basic project management.
Chloe: I take full responsibility for this. I relied on their standard timeline.
Victor: Okay. I appreciate your honesty, but we need to solve this problem immediately.
Chloe: Exactly. I did not want to come to you without a concrete plan.
Victor: Good. Do you have a realistic way out of this difficult mess?
Chloe: Can we walk through the options? I prepared two possible scenarios.
Victor: Go ahead, Chloe. I am listening to your plan.
Chloe: Here is what I suggest. We split the print run into two batches.
Victor: Can the printing company actually deliver a split run on time?
Chloe: Yes. They can run a smaller digital batch starting tomorrow morning.
Victor: Digital printing is significantly more expensive than our regular run, though.
Chloe: It will cost about fifteen percent more per unit, but only for the first run.
Victor: How many finished units can they give us before March first?
Chloe: They promised eight thousand fully printed units by February twenty-fourth.
Victor: But our total opening order is twenty-five thousand units across all retail chains.
Chloe: Eight thousand is not enough for everyone, but it covers our two key accounts.
Victor: You mean GrandMarket and FreshWay, our top two accounts?

Chloe: Exactly. GrandMarket ordered five thousand units, and FreshWay needs three thousand.
Victor: What about the smaller regional chains, like CityMart and QuickStop stores?
Chloe: We will have to push their delivery date back by ten days.
Victor: That will make them very angry. They already printed their promotional flyers.
Chloe: The bottom line is that GrandMarket and FreshWay represent seventy percent of our revenue.
Victor: That is completely true. Missing GrandMarket would kill the product launch instantly.
Chloe: If we supply GrandMarket and FreshWay on time, the main launch still happens.
Victor: What do we tell CityMart? They will definitely ask for compensation.
Chloe: We can offer them an extra five percent marketing discount on their second order.
Victor: That will protect our relationship and cost much less than contract penalties.
Chloe: That was my calculation too. It costs us around four hundred euros per chain.
Victor: When will the remaining seventeen thousand units arrive at our warehouse?
Chloe: The factory will deliver the main batch on March tenth.
Victor: March tenth means shelves will be fully stocked by March twelfth at the latest.
Chloe: That is correct. Regional stores will only see a ten-day delay.
Victor: Have you spoken to our warehouse team about weekend shifts yet?
Chloe: Yes. The warehouse manager confirmed they can pack and ship over the weekend.
Victor: That will require overtime pay for all our warehouse workers.
Chloe: It will. It adds roughly six hundred euros to our logistics budget.
Victor: Still, that extra cost is much better than losing shelf listings.
Chloe: I agree completely. It keeps our primary distribution channel active and safe.
Victor: What about our production facility? Are the actual snack bars ready?
Chloe: The product itself is ready and resting in bulk storage right now.
Victor: Good. So as soon as packaging arrives, packing begins immediately.
Chloe: Exactly. The packaging arrives on Friday morning, and packing starts at noon.
Victor: Okay, the logistics side looks solid. Now we need to discuss communication.
Chloe: Yes. **How should we proceed?**
Victor: We need to act quickly. Retailers hate surprises more than delays.
Chloe: Should I call all four category managers this afternoon with the news?
Victor: Not all of them. GrandMarket is our most sensitive partner right now.
Chloe: Do you want me to handle GrandMarket, or will you call their director?
Victor: I will handle this personally. I have known their commercial director for seven years.
Chloe: That will carry much more weight. They will appreciate a call from you directly.
Victor: I will tell him the first shipment arrives on February twenty-eighth as agreed.
Chloe: Perfect. That leaves FreshWay, CityMart, and QuickStop for me to call.
Victor: Yes. Call FreshWay first. Confirm that their three thousand units are guaranteed.
Chloe: Will do. They will be relieved that their full stock is secured.
Victor: Then call CityMart and QuickStop. Be very clear about the new date.
Chloe: Should I mention the machine breakdown at the printing facility?
Victor: No, never blame third parties. It makes us look unprofessional.
Chloe: Understood. I will frame it as a technical delay during final quality checks.
Victor: That sounds much better. It shows we prioritize quality for their customers.
Chloe: And I will immediately offer the five percent discount on their next order.
Victor: Good. Make sure you put that in writing right after the phone call.

Chloe: Of course. I will send official confirmation letters before five today.
Victor: What guarantees do we have from the printer this time?
Chloe: I requested a signed schedule from their general director this morning.
Victor: Did they sign the new commitment letter already?
Chloe: Yes. If they miss Friday, they will pay all digital printing costs themselves.
Victor: Excellent work on that point. That gives them a strong financial incentive.
Chloe: I also arranged a daily status call with their production head at nine.
Victor: Very good. That gives us direct control over the daily progress.
Chloe: I will track every thousand units produced until the order is complete.
Victor: Please keep me in the loop. Send me a quick text after each call.
Chloe: I will send a written update every morning by nine-thirty.
Victor: Let us check in again tomorrow at two to review the buyers' reactions.
Chloe: That works well for me. I will have all buyer responses ready.
Victor: Thank you, Chloe. You brought a problem, but you also brought a realistic solution.
Chloe: Thank you, Victor. I am going to call FreshWay right away.
Victor: Good luck. Let us get this launch back on track.

Key phrases from this episode

I have an urgent update regarding	used to introduce time-sensitive news clearly and immediately — I have an urgent update regarding the container shipment from Hamburg. — I have an urgent update regarding our quarterly sales targets.
We cannot afford to miss this.	this deadline or opportunity is too critical to fail — This contract is vital; we cannot afford to miss this. — The annual expo starts on Monday, and we cannot afford to miss this.
I take full responsibility for this.	accepting fault directly without making excuses — The report had calculation errors, and I take full responsibility for this. — I take full responsibility for this delay in signing the agreement.
Can we walk through the options?	asking to review available choices step by step — Can we walk through the options before we make a final decision? — Can we walk through the options for cutting transport costs?
Here is what I suggest.	introducing a concrete solution or recommendation directly — Here is what I suggest to resolve the warehouse bottleneck. — Here is what I suggest: we start with a small pilot phase.
The bottom line is that	highlighting the most important practical fact or result — The bottom line is that we need cash flow immediately. — The bottom line is that our top distributor wants lower prices.
How should we proceed?	asking for direction or approval on the next steps — The client rejected our proposal. How should we proceed? — We have received the revised budget. How should we proceed?
We need to act quickly.	urging immediate action to prevent further problems — The competitors are launching next week; we need to act quickly. — We need to act quickly before the customer cancels the order.
I will handle this personally.	promising to take individual charge of a sensitive task — This is an upset client, so I will handle this personally. — I will handle this personally to ensure there are no more errors.
Please keep me in the loop.	asking someone to provide regular updates on progress — Please keep me in the loop after you finish the audit call. — Please keep me in the loop regarding any changes to the shipment.

Common mistakes

✗ Not: ~~The packaging delivery is delayed on two weeks.~~
✓ Better: **The packaging delivery is delayed by two weeks.**
Use 'by' to indicate the amount of time in delays, not 'on'.

✗ Not: ~~Can you send me the actual schedule for printing?~~
✓ Better: **Can you send me the current schedule for printing?**
'Actual' means real, not up to date. Use 'current' for up-to-date information.

✗ Not: ~~Can you explain why is the delivery late?~~
✓ Better: **Can you explain why the delivery is late?**
In indirect questions after 'Can you explain why', use normal statement word order.

✗ Not: ~~I will warn the client about the new delivery date.~~
✓ Better: **I will notify the client about the new delivery date.**
'Warn' suggests danger. To give business updates or dates, use 'notify' or 'inform'.

✗ Not: ~~Who is responsible of communication with the retail chains?~~
✓ Better: **Who is responsible for communication with the retail chains?**
The adjective 'responsible' always takes the preposition 'for', not 'of'.

Quiz

1. Why is the snack bar launch at risk?
A) The packaging is delayed by two weeks.
B) The product recipe failed quality testing.
C) The warehouse workers went on strike.

2. How does Chloe propose to solve the packaging shortage?
A) Cancel all deliveries until mid-March.
B) Print a smaller digital batch first.
C) Find a completely new printing company.

3. Which retail chains will receive their orders on time?
A) CityMart and QuickStop.
B) All four retail chains.
C) GrandMarket and FreshWay.

4. Why will Victor contact GrandMarket's director himself?
A) He has known the director for seven years.
B) Chloe refused to make the phone call.
C) GrandMarket threatened legal action.

5. What does the phrase 'keep me in the loop' mean?
A) Exclude someone from future discussions.
B) Send regular updates about ongoing progress.
C) Repeat the same task several times.

Answers: 1-A 2-B 3-C 4-A 5-B

Dialogue voices are AI-generated. Every episode is built on a real, anonymized case from the host's 15+ years in FMCG and key account management.